

Andocides on the Mysteries and Athenian Political Life

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Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)

Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)

Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)

Andocides was an Athenian orator and politician who lived from approximately 440 BCE into the early fourth century BCE. Born into a wealthy family, his life was defined by his involvement in major Athenian scandals. In 415 BCE, he was implicated in the mutilation of sacred statues and the profanation of religious rites. To secure his safety, he gave testimony to the Athenian assembly, an act that led to his loss of civic rights and a period of exile, during which he worked as a merchant and ambassador.

He returned to Athens after a general amnesty in 403 BCE and sought to restore his political standing. His surviving speeches are direct records of these efforts. **On His Return** argues for his recall from exile, while his most famous work, **On the Mysteries**, is a defense against a later charge of impiety. This speech provides a crucial firsthand account of the 415 BCE scandals and Athenian legal procedures. His final major speech, **On the Peace with Sparta**, advocated for ending the Corinthian War in 391 BCE. Its failure led to his final exile. A fourth speech, **Against Alcibiades**, is attributed to him, but many scholars dispute its authenticity.

Andocides is counted among the ten canonical Attic orators, though his style is considered more straightforward and less refined than some of his peers. Modern scholars value his works primarily as historical documents. They offer a vivid, personal view of Athenian political and legal turmoil during the transition from the fifth to the fourth centuries BCE, illustrating the risks of public life and the complex debates over law, religion, and foreign policy.

Works (5)

- [Κατὰ Ἀλκιβιάδου](#) · [Against Alcibiades](#) · 37 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα πολιτικῶν λόγων](#) · [Fragments of Political Speeches](#) · 12 passages
- [Περὶ τῆς ἑαυτοῦ καθόδου](#) · [On His Own Descent](#) · 25 passages
- [Περὶ τῆς πρὸς Λακεδαιμονίους εἰρήνης](#) · [On Peace with the Lacedaemonians](#) · 39 passages
- [Περὶ τῶν μυστηρίων](#) · [On the Mysteries](#) · 125 passages